



textiles. Amongst these is Monika Correa's 'No Moon Tonight '(1974), a plain vertical weave broken by meandering patterns that hint at an abstraction drawn from nature. Textiles also make an appearance in Vidha Saumya's works, which are a part of 'The Pleasures We Choose', a multifaceted collaboration presented by the Pavilion of Finland. Meanwhile, Eva Kot'átková's project at the Czech and Slovak Republic Pavilion was made in collaboration with (amongst others) multi-disciplinary artist Himali Singh Soin.

Indian artists are also well-represented in a number of shows timed to coincide with the biennale, such as Mumbai-born textile artist Areez Katki, whose work is at the 'Personal Structures' event, and Singaporean Indian Priyageetha Dia, whose deep-sea video on ancestral migration from India to the Malay Peninsula is part of 'The Spirits of Maritime Crossing' event. And finally, there's 'Cosmic Garden', an artistic collaboration between Madhvi and Manu Parekh and the Mumbai-based Chanakya School of Craft. Through a series of paintings, embroideries and sculptures, the artists explore Indian myths and Vedic philosophy while highlighting India's rich cultural traditions and crafts. The Venice Biennale is on till November 24. ■

–Prachi Joshi

GREEN WONDER

Sculptor **Ranjani Shettar's** works at The Barbican Conservatory in London take inspiration from the natural world

London's tropical oasis, The Barbican Conservatory, spread over 23,000 square feet, is currently filled with delicate, handcrafted sculptures by Ranjani Shettar. Titled 'Cloud songs on the horizon', it's the artist's first major institutional show in Europe, featuring five large-scale suspended sculptures, drawing inspiration from the complexity of nature. The show, commissioned in partnership with the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art (KNMA), closes on July 28.

Titled 'Cloud songs on the horizon', this is Shettar's first major institutional show in Europe

Shettar says, "The exhibition has gone through different seasons. The Barbican Conservatory isn't an outdoor space but resembles one because of the glass roof. The light changes, so does the weather and also people's moods, but the artwork remains the same." When the sculptor first visited the Conservatory in December 2022, she felt a "deep connection" with the surroundings that have 1,500 plant species. Less than a year later, she was ready to show her creations that blend industrial and natural materials.

Each of Shettar's sculptures are an extension of what she does in her studio in Karnataka's rural Malnad. Passionate about nature and ecology, she goes a step ahead in using natural materials, including wood, stainless steel, muslin, lacquer and techniques that are rooted in traditional craft. "A garden is natural, but sometimes it's not, because we cultivate it selectively. I had to take a creative approach to the visual depiction of my pieces, making sure they stand out without getting competitive with what's around," she says.

Shettar admits every creation had its challenges. Laying down certain ground rules, she says, "Colour is something that has to really work. Besides that, lighting is important and serves as an active element."

With the show having garnered appreciation in the UK, are there plans to bring it to India? "I don't know what the future holds. If there's an opportunity to showcase it in our country, I will certainly go ahead with it," says Shettar. ■

–Geetika Sachdev





Photos courtesy: MAX COLSON, BARBICAN ART

Garden view (clockwise from below) Sculptor Ranjani Shettar and her works 'Moon dancers'; 'Cloud songs on the horizon' and 'In the thick of twilight'



